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LIBRARY COLUMN: Reading aloud - books for all reading levels



George Williams, Latah County Library District



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The year 2009 ended just a couple of weeks ago and it was a big year at our house. We had a new baby, and partly because I work at a library and partly because our family loves to read, little Marie ended up getting a bunch of books for her first Christmas.

I know though that no matter how many books you have, it's never enough. To make sure we don't run out of things to read in the new year I asked the people I work with to suggest the best books for reading aloud they came across in 2009. I thought I'd pass some of those suggestions along to you.

Betsy, our outreach services manager, had several titles for me. She thought Marie would enjoy "Knuffle Bunny" and "Knuffle Bunny Too" by Mo Willems. She's been using both of these in her day care storytimes as a part of the First Book program the library has been involved with for the past two years. Betsy also suggested "Tanka Tanka Skunk" by Steve Webb. Betsy likes these because they are bouncy rhyming books that play with words and language. Willems also wrote the "Pigeon" series of illustrated books that my older daughter, Persephone, has enjoyed for several years, so the "Knuffle Bunny" stories are probably going to find their way into our library soon. Since Betsy is suggesting books that have fun with words, I'm going to mention "Cow Moo Me" by Stephen Losordo. It's also a bouncy fun book that makes use of many words that fit together in fun ways.

Our Genesee branch supervisor, Connie, and one of our catalogers, Sheila, also had suggestions. Connie liked "The Pout-Pout Fish" by Deborah Diesen as another bouncy rhyming book. It tells the story of a fish who thinks it looks pouty and unpleasant until another fish comes along and sets it straight. Sheila suggested "Grumpa Grandpa" by Heather Henson, about a boy's visit to his aunt and uncle's house, where he meets his grumpy grandpa and learns that Grandpa hasn't always been so grumpy. Sheila also suggested "How Dinosaurs Go to

School" by Jane Yolen because it's a lively story about how dinosaurs should behave in school.

For reading aloud to an older crowd, our Potlatch branch supervisor, Donna, recommends the "Percy Jackson and the Olympians" series by Rick Riordan. Donna says her son, T.J., is currently reading the first book, "The Lightning Thief," to his son, Kelton, and they both love it. These books are about 12-year-old New Yorker Percy Jackson who learns that he is actually Perseus, son of Poseidon, one of the gods of Olympus.

For older kids, I'll also recommend the "Ranger's Apprentice" books by John Flanagan. Persephone and I didn't read them out loud together, but we did listen to the audio book version of "The Ruins of Gorlan" and "The Burning Bridge" when we were driving to and from southeastern Idaho this summer. This series tells the story of Will, the young apprentice to famed ranger Halt, as he and his master protect the kingdom of Araluen from outside forces.

Finally, for adults, Kathleen suggests "K2" by Ed Viesturs (with David Roberts). Kathleen's husband, Bill, has been reading it aloud at their house and Kathleen says that it "reads aloud like a scary fairy tale for adults: the mountain, the ice, the dark, the danger ... a fun book to listen to out loud while snuggled in your own warm bed."

So, happy belated New Year and happy reading to everyone. George Williams is access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

